A Gangotri of New India

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Long marches have always had a special place in history. Mahatma Gandhi's Dandi March and Mao's Long March are both examples of a disruptive political strategy that challenged the status quo. Even the Bharatiya Janata Party under L.K. Advani resorted to the Rath Yatra and numerous Shila yatras in the build-up to the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. Similarly, former Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar did the Bhondsi Yatra and Digvijaya Singh spearheaded the Narmada Yatra. All of these were smaller in scale, but had a huge impact on reshaping the narrative. Yet for the most part, dharnas (protests), pradarshans (demonstrations) and rail rokos (blocking trains) are the more prevalent forms of political campaigns in contemporary India. So when the Rahul Gandhi–led Kanyakumari-to-Kashmir Bharat Jodo Yatra was first announced, there was a general sense of disbelief at how such a vast distance could be traversed in the time proposed and how the logistics would be managed (especially given the false notions that the BJP has deliberately fomented about the Congress party).

Yet, since the Yatra's flag-off moment, the tempo and scale only kept growing. With remarkable determination, the Yatra relentlessly proceeded day after day with little rest or halt. Rahul himself faced tremendous difficulties because of an old muscle injury. But he didn't let that stop or slow him down, and steadfastly pushed on. It is in large part due to his incredible mental and physical stamina that the Yatra eventually succeeded. In fact, he also displayed tremendous maturity and wisdom in compassionately interacting with the lakhs of people who excitedly followed, surrounded, reached out to touch, shook hands with and even